

L-51: Indian Society — Comprehensive Notes

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Paper 2 — Chapters 4, 5.2, 5.3, 5.3a | Also relevant to GS1 Society

Sanskritization

Westernization

Modernization

Religious & Linguistic Minorities

Growth of Anthropology in India

Panchayati Raj & Social Change

Media & Social Change



MASTER TOPIC MAP — L-51 Overview & Inter-linkages

PROCESSES of Social Change:

- Sanskritization (Ch 5.3a)
- Westernization (Ch 5.3a)
- Modernization (Ch 5.3a)

SUBJECTS of Change:

- Religious & Linguistic Minorities (Ch 5.2)

AGENTS of Change:

- Panchayati Raj (Ch 5.3)
- Media & Social Change

STUDY of Change:

- Growth of Anthropology in India (Ch 4)

Unifying Thread: All 7 topics connect through *processes, agents, and subjects of social change in Indian society* — the central concern of Indian anthropology.

Key Inter-linkages to remember:

- Sanskritization ↔ Westernization (accelerate & weaken each other — Srinivas)
- Media = new agent of Sanskritization (online poojas, TV festivals) AND of modernization
- PRI + Media = drivers of social change for minorities & tribals (PESA + media coverage)
- Growth of Anthropology → analytical phase studied ALL these processes
- Minorities face challenges from BOTH Sanskritization (cultural homogenization) AND modernization (economic marginalization)

TOPIC 1: SANSKRITIZATION

Paper 2 — Chapter 5.3a | Also relevant to GS1 (Social Change)

M. N. Srinivas — coined the concept in his first systematic study:

"Religion and Society among the Coorgs of South India" (1952)

Definition: "The process by which a low caste or tribe or other group takes over the customs, rituals, beliefs, ideology and lifestyle of a higher caste and in particular 'twice born' (dwija) caste."

Core Argument: The caste system in India has **never been so rigid** that individuals or castes cannot alter or raise their status.

Role of Dominant Castes

- Mediation of Sanskritization models shaped by **local dominant castes**
- **Brahmin-dominated areas** → Brahminical model of emulation
- **Rajput or Bania-dominated areas** → Kshatriya or Vaishya models
- Thus Sanskritization is **not a single process** but varies regionally 

Changes Adopted During Sanskritization (Cultural Emulation)

- Giving up **non-vegetarianism, alcohol consumption, animal sacrifice**
- Imitating Brahmin lifestyle in **food, dress, and rituals**
- Donning of **sacred thread**
- Giving up sacrifice of **pigs at weddings** 
- System of **dowry replacing bride price**
- All of the above = **Cultural Emulation** → leads to **Cultural Erosion**

Regional Examples of Sanskritization

Region	Community	Claim/Action
Bihar	Rajwars (SC)	Claim Kshatriya status
Bihar	Koyeris (BC)	Identify as Kushwaha Kshatriya
Bihar	Dusadh (SC)	Adopt identity of Gahlout Kshatriya
Maharashtra & Rajasthan	Mahar and Pasi castes	Abandon polluting occupations
Central India	Gonds, Cheros, Sudha Saoras, Paudi Bhuiyans	Undergo Sanskritization
Rajasthan	Meena	Absorbed into Hindu fold
Bihar & West Bengal	Santhal, Munda	Absorbed into Hindu fold
UP	Jounsari, Khasas, Tharu	Absorbed into Hindu fold

Impact on Women & Family Structure

- Autonomy of women and freedom to choose life partner is **LOST**
- Family structure shifts to **orthodox Hindu joint family** with strong paternal authority and monogamy
- Food habits change (beef, pork, liquor abandoned)
- **Dowry system replaces bride price** — a regressive shift

Hostility Faced by Lower Castes During Sanskritization

- Middle-strata castes **resist upward mobility** of lower castes
- Violence and taxation used to enforce hierarchy

Case Study: Nangeli of Travancore

Lower caste women (Nadars, Ezhavas) had to pay **mulakkaram** ("breast tax") to cover their upper bodies.

Nangeli — an Ezhava woman who cut off her breasts in protest and died of blood loss.

For men: **talakkaram** (head tax) or **meeshakkaram** (moustache tax) 

Significance: Shows how upper castes used economic instruments to enforce social hierarchy and prevent lower caste assertion.

Negative Effects of Sanskritization

- Lower castes are **ironically more liberal** in matters of women's rights, sexual conduct, freedom of marriage
- But Sanskritization makes them **conservative and retrograde**

- Examples of regressive adoption: **dowry, early marriage, purdah**
- Loss of indigenous cultural practices and identity

The Paradox of Sanskritization

"Lower" castes that become prosperous/educated claim **higher status** through Sanskritization. At the same time, they **fiercely retain "backward" status** to avail reservations/jobs. "Modern India is full of contradictions." ✎

Other Motives — Harold Gould (1988)

Harold Gould (1988)

*"The prime motive force behind Sanskritization is the factor of **repressed hostility** which manifests itself not in the form of rejecting the caste system but in the form of its victims trying to **seize control of it** and thereby expiate their frustrations on the same battlefield where they acquired them."*

- In short: not just to gain status, but to **show capability** equal to former oppressors
- It is a form of **psychological empowerment** within the existing system

New Agents of Sanskritization

- Srinivas: Festivals of village deities and calendrical festivals are increasingly Sanskritized
- **Newspapers, microphone, radio/television** = new agents of Sanskritization ✎
- Example: **Booking a Tirupati pooja online** → indirectly strengthens Sanskritization ✎
- TV serials like Ramayana/Mahabharata episodes → standardize Brahminical narrative

Sanskritization Among Non-Hindu Communities

- Cultural emulation for status elevation is the prime motive **even among non-Hindu communities**
- **Tribal absorption into Hindu fold**: A tribe undergoing Sanskritization becomes a caste, establishing regular relations with local castes
- This is how the **tribe-caste continuum** operates (link to L-49)

Variants of Sanskritization

a. Resanskritization

- **Meaning**: A group temporarily moves away from Sanskritic practices, then **returns** to them
- **Explanation**: Groups adopt reformist/modernist/Western practices, then re-adopt Brahmanical practices due to social pressure, revivalist movements, or identity reassertion

📌 Case: Lingayats in Karnataka

Originally a radical bhakti movement by **Basavanna** (12th century) that rejected Brahminical orthodoxy (no idol worship, no caste). Later sections incorporated idol worship and temple rituals → **classic example of resanskritization**.

- Another example: **Arya Samaj followers** — rejected idol worship, but later generations reintroduced Sanskritic practices

b. Desanskritization

- **Meaning**: Groups that had adopted Sanskritic practices **deliberately abandon** them to revive indigenous traditions
- **Explanation**: Arises from disillusionment with Sanskritization (it fails to deliver actual mobility), or from tribal assertion and identity movements

Example	Details
Ramnamis of Chhattisgarh	Dalit sect adopting Vaishnav bhakti, but tattooed "Ram" on bodies and rejected Brahminical/priestly mediation . Direct devotion without intermediaries.
Jharkhand Tribal Movements	Santhal, Munda, Ho, Oraon — Sarna revivalism emphasizes worship of nature spirits and ancestral rituals, rejecting Hindu deities and temples
Adi Dharma Movement	Dalits in Bengal rejected Brahmanical Hinduism and reclaimed distinct cultural identity outside Hinduism entirely

Scholar Summary — Sanskritization

Scholar	Key Argument
M. N. Srinivas	Coined concept; multiple models (Brahmin/Kshatriya/Vaishya) depending on dominant caste; never fully structural
Milton Singer (1968)	Multiple models exist; contemporary mobility is less about Sanskritization, more about political participation
Yogendra Singh	Extended Sanskritization beyond castes to <i>varna</i> framework; critiqued focus on hierarchy; said it manifests repressed inter-class hostility
William Rowe	Sanskritization is less functional today compared to political participation as means of mobility
Harold Gould (1988)	Prime motive = repressed hostility ; victims seize control rather than reject the system

Key Takeaway: Sanskritization gains are largely **symbolic rather than structural**. Contemporary India increasingly uses education, politics, and law for dignity and equality beyond Sanskritic models. It explains *cultural change* but not *structural transformation*.

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

- **Methodological:** Srinivas introduced the concept through **participant observation** among Coorgs — showed how fieldwork reveals social dynamics invisible to census/survey methods
- **Challenges unilineal evolution:** Social change in India is NOT linear progress but **cyclical, contested, and multi-directional** (re-/de-sanskritization prove this)
- **Identity politics today:** Jat/Patel/Maratha agitations for OBC status = modern variant of the "paradox" — claim both high status AND backwardness
- **Cultural rights discourse:** Desanskritization movements (Sarna code demand, Lingayat separate religion demand in Karnataka) show how communities resist cultural homogenization
- **Gender lens:** Sanskritization is **anti-feminist** — anthropologists document how caste mobility comes at the cost of women's autonomy (bride price → dowry; freedom → purdah)
- **Tribal policy relevance:** Understanding Sanskritization is crucial for deciding between isolation, integration, and assimilation approaches to tribal development

Mnemonic: SANSKRITIZATION = "SACRED CLIMB"

Status elevation | Adoption of upper caste practices |
Cultural emulation → erosion | Repressed hostility
(Gould) | Erosion of women's rights | Dominant caste
models

TOPIC 2: WESTERNIZATION

Paper 2 — Chapter 5.3a | Also relevant to GS1 (Social Change, Globalization)

M. N. Srinivas coined the term.

Refers to all **cultural changes and institutional innovations** in India due to more than **150 years of British rule** and contact with Western nations.

Wider plane: Scientific approach, materialism (over spiritualism), individualism, liberal approach, humanism, equality, egalitarianism, rationalism.

Impacts of Westernization in India

Domain	Impact
Scientific & Educational	Modern schools, colleges, universities, scientific institutions
Political	Rise of nationalism, modern leadership, democratic institutions, new political culture
Caste & Family	Lessening of caste rigidity, disintegration of joint families, social reform movements
Economic	Decline of cottage industries, promotion of commercial crops, new land management
Social Values	Democracy, equality, social justice, uniform administration

- Humanitarianism and rationalism → social reform movements: **abolition of sati, widow remarriage**
- Rise of social reformers like **Raja Ram Mohan Roy**

Westernization ↔ Sanskritization — The Link (Srinivas)

Relationship	Mechanism
Westernization ACCELERATES Sanskritization	Railways, post, newspapers increased pilgrimages, caste meetings, religious propaganda → wider reach of Sanskrit practices
Westernization WEAKENS Sanskritization	Highly Westernized people live in the "world of class rather than caste"; drop caste names, intermarry, give up sacred thread

Harold Gould — on Higher Castes & Westernization

Once a caste is fully Sanskritized, it **cannot rise further** within the ritual hierarchy. So higher castes used **Western lifestyles as an alternative form of distinction** — education, English language, modern professions became new markers of superiority. 🖋️

Three Global Views on Westernization

View	Scholar	Key Argument
Conflict View	Samuel Huntington (<i>Clash of Civilizations</i>)	Westernization brings cultural conflicts between West and Rest . Three responses: 1. Isolation (reject contact) 2. Band-wagoning (openly join Western values) 3. Balancing (modernize while retaining cultural identity)
Optimistic View	Kishore Mahbubani (<i>The New Asian Hemisphere</i>)	A new global civilization is emerging; non-Western nations admire Western standards but world must adopt shared policies. Western influence is unraveling as Eastern powers (China, India) rise
Critical View	Edward Said (<i>Orientalism</i> , 1978)	Westernization = colonial domination ; West essentialized subject populations, reinforced own superiority. Balfour argued Egyptians needed British guidance. Knowledge and domination intertwined

Indian Context

- John McLane** — Indian nationalist movement drew heavily from Western ideas of democracy and rights
- B. R. Nanda** — Observed that **Jawaharlal Nehru** carried such "Britishness" that he once called himself "the last Englishman to rule India" 🖋️
- Westernization gave India the ideological foundation for **nationalism, democracy, and social reform**

Limitations of Westernization (as a concept)

#	Limitation	Explanation
1	Over-generalised concept	Clubs very different influences (railways, education, democracy, dress) under one label
2	Eurocentric bias	Assumes Western values are inherently progressive; ignores indigenous reforms
3	Neglects selective adoption	Communities accepted modern science but resisted Christianization
4	Ignores resistance	Swadeshi movement, revivalist reform movements not adequately accounted for
5	Static view of "the West"	Treats the West as a fixed model, ignoring its internal contradictions and evolving nature 🖋️

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

- **Postcolonial critique:** Edward Said's *Orientalism* reshaped how anthropologists understand power relations in fieldwork — the "gaze" of the observer matters
- **Globalization link:** Contemporary Westernization manifests as **cultural homogenization** (McDonald's, Netflix) but also triggers **cultural assertion** (yoga diplomacy, Ayush push)
- **Selective Westernization:** India adopted parliamentary democracy but retained caste-based personal laws — anthropologists study this **selective borrowing** process
- **Digital colonialism debate:** Silicon Valley platforms (Meta, Google) as new agents of Westernization — data extraction parallels resource extraction
- **Re-Sanskritization as backlash:** Growing inclination towards yoga, Ayurveda, ancient philosophy = response to perceived over-Westernization (contemporary trend, 2025-26)
- **For UPSC:** Always use "Westernization" alongside "modernization" — show you understand the distinction (value-loaded vs value-neutral). Connect to tribe-caste continuum: tribal Westernization ≠ tribal Sanskritization

TOPIC 3: MODERNIZATION

Paper 2 — Chapter 5.3a | Also relevant to GS1 (Social Change, Development)

Definitions

Eisenstadt

"From a historical viewpoint, modernization is the process of change towards those types of social, economic, and political systems which were developed in Western Europe and North America from the 17th to 19th centuries, and later spread to South America, Asia, and Africa."

Yogendra Singh

"Modernization symbolizes a **rational attitude** towards issues and their evaluation, not from a particularistic point of view."

- Rests on the idea of **progress** — scientific, technological, and institutional advancement improves human condition
- Implies decline of feudalism, superstition, and rigid dogmatism

Key Features of Modernization

- Based on progress in science, technology, and social organization
- Decline in feudalism, superstition, and rigid dogmatism
- Promotes rationality, equality, democracy, and secularism

Historical Roots of Modernization

Phase	Period	Key Developments
Neolithic Revolution	c. 10,000 BCE	Development of ploughs & refined stone tools → raised land productivity → nomadic bands settled into permanent villages → surplus production → specialization (artisans, merchants, priests, administrators) → first leap toward organized societies
Industrial Revolution	18th-19th Century	Steam engine, electricity, telegraph, factory system. Agricultural modernization: Denmark & NZ industrialized farms → "rural factories". Dismantled agrarian hierarchies, created new classes. Political revolutions: American & French introduced democracy
Cultural Dimension	1904	Max Weber — "The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism": Protestantism encouraged rational discipline and work ethic ("this-worldly orientation") unlike Catholicism and Eastern religions (more otherworldly) → suited for industrial capitalism

Modernization vs Westernization — KEY DISTINCTION

S. C. Dube (1988)

"Modernization is **less value-loaded** than Westernization. While Westernization implies borrowing Western practices, modernization emphasizes rational and scientific progress **without threatening cultural identity**."

Westernization = Modernization (overlap)

Railways, telegraphs, postal services, English education → modernized infrastructure

Constitutional democracy modernized political structures

Westernization ≠ Modernization (distinction)

Blind imitation of fashion, fast food, Valentine's Day → NOT modernization

Wearing suits in Indian summers lacks rationality 🖋️

Modernization Beyond the West

- Borrowing from other societies: **Green Revolution** in India drew from Mexico and Philippines
- Indigenous reform: **Arya Samaj, Brahmo Samaj, Gandhi's Khadi and Panchayati Raj** = modernization from within

Key Takeaway: Westernization may sometimes lead to modernization, but modernization is broader — can come from Western, non-Western, or indigenous sources. Japan modernized without fully Westernizing.

Features of a Modernized Personality — Daniel Lerner

Feature	Meaning	Example
1. Empathy	Ability to see from another's perspective	B. R. Ambedkar's temple entry & anti-untouchability struggles; Saudi Arabia's relaxation of rigid dress codes
2. Mobility	Both geographical and social mobility	Ambedkar's rise from untouchable origins to chief framer of Constitution; lifting of driving ban for Saudi women
3. High Participation	Greater involvement in political, economic, social life	Dalits mobilizing through Ambedkar's leadership; Saudi women joining workforce and politics under Vision 2030

Indian Model of Modernization

S. C. Dube (1974)

"There is no standard model of modernization and no fixed path for its attainment. Developing societies can adopt a model of *their own choice*."

- India's chosen path: **democracy, secularism, and social justice**
- Adoption of modern science and technology is central
- Example: **Directive Principle Article 48** — modernizing agriculture and animal husbandry
- Challenges: regional imbalances, corruption, nepotism, uneven diffusion of benefits

Contemporary Issues in Modernization

- Superstition vs Rationality:** NCRB data (2021) — **74 deaths from witchcraft and human sacrifice** → reveals gaps in modernization
- Activist **Narendra Dabholkar** campaigned for national anti-superstition law (assassinated 2013)
- Women's Rights:** Demands for entry into mosques, equal inheritance laws
- Religious Conservatism:** Women activists/minorities branded as "Westernized" or "anti-religion"

Limitations of Modernization Theory

#	Limitation	Example
1	Not uniform or linear	IT hubs of Bengaluru coexist with witchcraft-related deaths in Jharkhand
2	Neglects inequality & exclusion	Green Revolution raised productivity but widened class divides; tribal/rainfed areas left behind
3	Resistance from conservatism	Modern reforms branded as "Western" or "anti-tradition"
4	Overemphasis on progress	Environmental degradation, urban alienation, consumerism as costs
5	Alternative modernities overlooked	Gandhian decentralization, indigenous tribal sustainable models sidelined; Gandhi's Panchayati Raj dismissed as "backward" during Nehru's heavy industry focus



Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

- Critique of development:** Anthropologists (Arturo Escobar, James Scott) show modernization theory imposes a single trajectory — ignores **alternative modernities** (tribal sustainable models, Gandhian village)
- Multiple modernities thesis:** Every society modernizes differently — India's path through caste-based democracy, religious pluralism is unique (not a "failed West")
- Applied anthropology:** Development projects (dams, mining) justified as "modernization" often displace tribals — anthropologists document the **human cost of progress**
- Digital India as modernization:** Aadhaar, UPI, DBT = contemporary modernization without Westernization — indigenously developed systems
- Witchcraft deaths paradox:** NCRB data shows modernization penetration is uneven — anthropologists study why rational modernity fails to displace magical beliefs in specific contexts
- Weber's thesis relevance:** Debate on whether Indian religions (karma, dharma) inhibit or promote capitalism — Yogendra Singh's counter that Hindu other-worldliness is overstated



Mnemonic: S-W-M COMPARISON

Sanskritization = Status within hierarchy (symbolic, cultural) | Westernization = Whole cultural import (value-loaded, Eurocentric) | Modernization = Mind-change (rational, value-neutral, universal)

Relationship: S ↔ W (accelerate/weaken each other) | W → M (sometimes leads to) | M ≠ W always (can be indigenous)

TOPIC 4: RELIGIOUS & LINGUISTIC MINORITIES

Paper 2 — Chapter 5.2 | Also relevant to GS1 (Diversity), GS2 (Polity)

A. RELIGIOUS MINORITIES

Census Data — Religious Communities of India (2011)

Religious Group	Population (million)	% of Total
Hindus	966.3	79.8%
Muslims	172.2	14.2%
Christians	27.8	2.3%
Sikhs	20.8	1.7%
Buddhists	8.4	0.7%
Jains	4.5	0.4%
Other Religions & Persuasions (ORP)	7.9	0.7%
Religion Not Stated	2.9	0.2%

Constitutional Provisions for Minorities

- Term "Minorities" appears at **only four places** in the Indian Constitution
- No definition** of the term is given in the Constitution

Article	Provision
Article 29	Protection of interests of minorities — speaks of "any sections of citizens having a distinct language, script or culture "
Article 30	Right of minorities to establish and administer educational institutions (religious OR linguistic minorities)
Article 350-A	Instruction in mother tongue at primary stage for linguistic minority children
Article 350-B	Special Officer for linguistic minorities appointed by President (inserted by Constitution 7th Amendment Act, 1956)

Lord Acton

"The most certain test by which we judge whether a country is really free is the amount of **security enjoyed by minorities.**"

Who are Religious Minorities?

- A group whose religion is held by a minority of a population
- Initially **five** communities notified: **Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Zoroastrians (Parsis)**
- On **27th January 2014**, **Jains** were also notified as 6th minority community

Problems of Religious Minorities — 7 Key Issues

Problem	Details & Data
1. Identity	Socio-cultural differences, history & background; difficulty adjusting with majority community
2. Security	Feelings of insecurity about life, assets, well-being; accentuated when majority-minority relations strained
3. Equity	Deprived of development opportunities due to discrimination. UNDP & Oxford (OPHI) MPI 2018 : "Every second ST, every third Dalit and Muslim in India poor, not just financially"
4. Communal Tension & Riots	2013 Muzaffarnagar riots — widespread violence & displacement; 2002 Godhra Riots — Train burning 27 Feb 2002, death of 69 Hindu pilgrims, triggered communal violence
5. Under-representation	Sachar Committee : Muslims = 14% population but only 2.5% of bureaucracy and 5% in politics
6. Politicization	Karnataka Hijab Controversy 2022 (see case study below)
7. Fear Mongering	CAA 2019 — excluded Muslims from fast-tracked citizenship → Shaheen Bagh women protesters painted as "anti-national" or "funded by outsiders" 🗡️

📌 Case Study: Karnataka Hijab Controversy (2022)

- February 2022**: Muslim students denied entry to Karnataka junior college for wearing hijabs
- Hindu students counter-protested in saffron scarves
- Karnataka government directed uniforms without exceptions
- 15 March 2022**: Karnataka High Court **upheld the ban** — ruled hijab is "not an essential religious practice"
- Criticized by **Malala Yousafzai** and **Human Rights Watch**
- Anthropological lens**: Shows how religious symbols become sites of identity contestation in modern democracies

Important Cases

- Ashwini Upadhyay's PIL**: Court said no new religious group to be recognised as minority; NCM must work towards reducing the list
- Court's approach called "assimilation" — but Constitution wants **integration, not assimilation**

Justice Ranganath Mishra Commission — Key Recommendations

Recommendation	Details
Reservations	10% for Muslims + 5% for other minorities in Central/State govt jobs
OBC Sub-quota	In 27% OBC quota → 8.4% sub-quota for minorities (6% Muslims + 2.4% others) since minorities = 8.4% of OBC per Mandal
Delink SC from religion	Abrogate 1950 SC Order which excludes Muslims, Christians, Jains, Parsis from SC net (only Hindus, Buddhists, Sikhs included)
ST status	Carefully examine extent of minority presence in ST category
Education	Establish Morarji Desai Residential Schools and PU colleges for minorities at taluk level; minority women hostels

B. LINGUISTIC MINORITIES

Definition: A linguistic minority = people whose **mother tongue is different from the majority in the state or part of a state.**

Determined on a **state-wide basis** (not national basis).

Important Court Cases

Case	Year	Ruling
DAV College vs. State of Punjab	1971	SC defined linguistic minority as one that has at least a spoken language, regardless of having a script or not
TA Pai Foundation vs. State of Karnataka	—	Status of linguistic minority to be determined in the context of states and not India as a whole

Problems of Linguistic Minorities — 6 Key Issues

Problem	Details
1. Lack of funds for minority language education	XAXA Committee on Tribes: Low literacy among PVTGs due to poor infrastructure, poorly trained teachers, lack of teaching in tribal languages , irrelevant curriculum. Rapid shift to English medium → indigenous minorities lose own language
2. Language Diversity challenge	Preserve languages against dominance of major languages (Hindi, English)
3. Grievance redressal barrier	Having to use majority's language for official communication and representation
4. Social Discrimination	Made to feel like outsiders in social and professional settings
5. Cultural Erosion	Influence of major languages leads to erosion of unique linguistic and cultural identities
6. Economic Disparities	Economic opportunities correlate with proficiency in major languages; disadvantage for linguistic minorities

Conclusion: "A civilisation can be judged by the way it treats its minorities." Empowerment through affirmative action, inclusive development, equitable share in education, employment, and economy. Implementing **Justice Ranganath Mishra Commission** recommendations is the way forward.

Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

- **Ethnographic documentation:** Anthropologists document minority cultures, languages, and practices that are disappearing — preserving them for posterity (e.g., Asur language with only 7000-8000 speakers)
- **Identity formation:** Anthropology studies how minority identity is **constructed, contested, and negotiated** — not fixed but fluid (e.g., Pasmanda vs Ashraf Muslim divide)
- **Integration vs Assimilation:** Anthropological perspective favors **integration** (retain identity while participating in larger society) over assimilation (losing identity) — directly relevant to policy
- **SC ruling 2024-25:** Minority status is "state-dependent" — Hindus can be minority in some states (J&K, Punjab, NE) — validates anthropological view that identity is **contextual, not absolute**
- **Language death:** UNESCO estimates 197 Indian languages are endangered — anthropological fieldwork is the primary method of recording dying languages and oral traditions
- **Communalism study:** Anthropologists analyze communal riots not just as political events but as breakdowns in **inter-community reciprocity networks** that traditionally maintained peace
- **Tribal-minority overlap:** Many tribals are both religious AND linguistic minorities — PESA and FRA address this intersectionality

TOPIC 5: GROWTH OF ANTHROPOLOGY IN INDIA

Paper 2 — Chapter 4 | Direct question in almost every alternate year

Overview

- Development of anthropological thought in India was **slow but steady**
- Four generally accepted phases
- Moved from **documenting indigenous traditions** to **critically analysing theories and methods**

Four Phases at a Glance

Phase 1: FORMATIVE
(1774–1919)
→ Documentation & Description

Phase 3: ANALYTICAL
(1950–1990)
→ Theory & Complex Studies

Phase 2: CONSTRUCTIVE (1920–1949)
→ Institution Building

Phase 4: EVALUATIVE
(1990–present)
→ Applied & New Subfields

Phase 1: Formative Phase (1774–1919)

- Emphasis on **tribal life and diversity of customs**
- Many handbooks, ethnographies, and gazettes on tribes and castes published
- Revenue reports of **Dalton, Buchanon, and Lord Baden Powell** examined socio-cultural situation 
- 1774**: Foundation of **Asiatic Society of India** by **Sir William Jones**
- Became Asiatic Society of Bengal in 1784; started publishing journal
- H. H. Risley** published report on *Tribes and Castes of Bengal* (1891)
- Risley later became Head of Census operations and conducted ethnographic surveys

Contribution of Indian Anthropologists (Formative Phase)

- 1912** — **S. C. Roy** published the monograph "**Munda and Their Country**"
- Wrote on other tribes of Central India
- Roy is often called the "**Father of Indian Ethnography**"

Phase 2: Constructive Phase (1920–1949)

- Anthropology introduced in Sociology Dept of **Bombay University (1919)**
- Entered PG curriculum of **Calcutta University by 1920**
- Publication of journal "**Man in India**" (1921) under editorship of **S. C. Roy**
- 25th Indian Science Congress (1938, Calcutta)**: Focal theme "Anthropology in India" — first review of anthropological research in India (joint session of Indian Science Congress and British Association)

Verrier Elwin (1939)

Published book "**The Baiga**" — proposed that tribes should be **left alone** to develop in isolation from the mainstream (**Isolationist approach**). Later moderated his views and supported **Nehru's integrationist approach**.

- 1945**: Establishment of **Anthropological Survey of India (AnSI)**
- First Director: **B. S. Guha**, headquartered at Calcutta

Phase 3: Analytical Phase (1950–1990)

- Indian anthropologists began interacting regularly with **American anthropologists** — collaborative works
- Shift from descriptive studies of preliterate societies to analytical studies of complex societies**
- Foreign anthropologists came to India; villages they studied became famous
- Large number of **village study monographs** published in 1950s–60s
- Key scholars: **Redfield, Singer, Marriott** and others
- New concepts and ideas generated; distinct research methodologies developed
- L. P. Vidyarthi** — studied **sacred complexes, nature-man-spirit complex** in tribal societies

Phase 4: Evaluative Phase (1990 to Present)

- New areas and subfields of Anthropology emerging
- Increased interest in:

Subfield	Focus Area
Medical Anthropology	Health beliefs, traditional medicine, disease in cultural context
Religion Studies	Integrated study of tribal religions, sacred geography
Development Studies	Tribal identity, integration, vanishing culture and planning
Industrial Anthropology	Workplace culture, organizational behavior
Psychological Studies	Personality, cognition in cultural context
Action Research	Participatory research with communities for social change
Folk-lore Research	Oral traditions, myths, legends as cultural data
Power Structure Studies	Leadership, authority, local governance structures

Key Scholars — Complete Timeline

Scholar	Contribution	Phase
Sir William Jones	Founded Asiatic Society of India (1774)	1
H. H. Risley	Tribes & Castes of Bengal (1891); Head of Census; ethnographic surveys	1
Dalton, Buchanon, Baden Powell	Revenue reports examining socio-cultural situations 📝	1
S. C. Roy	"Munda & Their Country" (1912); founded/edited "Man in India" (1921)	1 & 2
Verrier Elwin	"The Baiga" (1939); isolationist approach to tribal policy	2
B. S. Guha	First Director of AnSI (1945), Calcutta	2
Redfield, Singer, Marriott	Village studies; Great/Little Tradition; universalisation-parochialisation	3
L. P. Vidyarthi	Sacred complexes; nature-man-spirit complex in tribal societies	3



Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

- **Self-reflexivity:** Indian anthropology moved from being a **colonial tool** (Risley's racial classifications used to divide) to a **decolonized discipline** that questions its own origins
- **Applied anthropology today:** AnSI's "People of India" project (K.S. Singh) documented 4635 communities — largest anthropological survey globally. Used in policy (SC/ST identification)
- **Development anthropology:** Anthropologists now sit on **EIA panels, rehabilitation committees, PVTG planning cells** — directly influencing policy
- **Tribal policy evolution:** The shift from Elwin's isolationism to Nehru's integration to current "development with dignity" approach mirrors anthropology's own theoretical growth
- **Digital anthropology:** Phase 4 now includes studying **digital cultures, social media behavior, AI ethics** — newest frontier
- **For UPSC:** This topic directly connects to "Role of Anthropology in Development" (Ch 9.2) and "Tribal Policy" — use phases to show how theory informed policy at each stage



Mnemonic: Phases = F-C-A-E ("FACE of Indian Anthropology")

Formative (Document) → Constructive (Institutionalize)
 → Analytical (Theorize) → Evaluative (Apply)
 Key years: **1774** (Asiatic Society) → **1921** (Man in India)
 → **1945** (AnSI) → **1950s** (Village studies) → **1990+** (Applied)

TOPIC 6: PANCHAYATI RAJ & SOCIAL CHANGE

Paper 2 — Chapter 5.3 | Also relevant to GS1 (Social Change), GS2 (Governance)

What is Social Change?

- "Any major change in behaviour patterns, cultural values, and customs over time" = social change
- By "significant" modification, anthropologists mean changes yielding **profound social consequences**

Anderson and Parker

Social change involves **alteration in the structure and functioning** of societal forms or processes themselves.

Surinder S. Jodhka

Social change refers to **changes in values, institutions and practices** of society.

What is Panchayati Raj?

Panchayati Raj = oldest system of local government in the Indian subcontinent

- "Panchayat" = assembly (*ayat*) of **five (panch)** and *raj* = "rule"
- A group of elders chosen by local community to settle disputes
- Leader called **Mukhya or Sarpanch**
- Type of **direct democracy** (exercises all powers of government at village level)

Three-Tier PRI Structure

Level	Body	Function
Village	Gram Panchayat	Local governance, basic services, development
Intermediate (Block)	Panchayat Samiti	Coordination between village and district
District	Zilla Panchayat	District-level planning, resource allocation

Panchayati Raj as Tool of Social Change

1. Leadership from Less Privileged Sections

- **Gram Sabha** — all eligible voters can participate → includes less privileged sections
- Reservation for SCs and STs as chairpersons in panchayats
- **Women's Reservation:**

Bihar = first state to reserve **50% panchayat seats for women**, followed by 15 others (Uttarakhand, HP, MP, Kerala, Tripura, Maharashtra). 🖊️

Challenge: "Sarpanch pati" phenomenon — husband of woman sarpanch calling the shots. PM Modi raised this on National Panchayati Raj Day, 24 April. 🖊️

2. Tribals and Social Change — PESA

PESA (Panchayats Extension to Scheduled Areas Act)

Addresses: tribal customary rights, cultural rights, language & identity, rights to land, water, forests, and minerals.

Emphasizes: **right of tribal people to maintain and strengthen their own institutions, cultures and traditions** and pursue development according to their own aspirations.

3. Other Social Change Initiatives through PRI

- Tracking health outcomes: preventing childhood malnutrition
- Nutritious food for pregnant women below poverty line
- Preventing deaths during childbirth
- Social peace, farmer welfare, rural development
- Urban utilities to villages
- Open-defecation-free communities, sufficient toilets for women

Case Studies of Panchayati Raj in Action

Case Study	Location	Achievement
Ban on Alcohol	Rajsamand's Bhim tehsil, Rajasthan (2015)	Women campaign → permanent closure of liquor shops in Barar & Hamela Ki Ver villages. Rule: 51% registered voters can close a liquor shop
Decentralized Planning	Latak, Assam's Dhemaji district	Village of 300 houses built a bamboo bridge to connect flood-affected areas — funded entirely from own resources
Social Welfare	Digampur, West Bengal	'Direct-to-home' drinking water, doorstep garbage collection, handicrafts from organic manure. Won first prize — Gram Panchayat Vikas Yojana
Environment Conservation	Odisha Gram Panchayats	Plantation activities 2020-21 for green cover, climate change mitigation, income generation (though critiqued as top-down/non-participatory)
Social Development	ACNielsen ORG-MARG Survey (Ministry of PR)	PRI representatives taking up: child marriage discouragement, gambling, alcoholism



Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

- **Power structure studies:** Anthropologists study how **traditional authority** (caste elders, landlords) conflicts with democratic PRI authority — the transition is ongoing and contested
- **PESA and customary law:** Anthropological documentation of tribal customary practices (land tenure, dispute resolution, sacred groves) is essential for PESA implementation
- **Gender dynamics:** Ethnographic studies of women sarpanches reveal the "Sarpanch pati" phenomenon — formal political power ≠ actual decision-making authority
- **Decentralization vs homogenization:** PRI can either **protect local diversity** (through PESA) or **homogenize** governance — anthropologists document both outcomes
- **Recent (2025-26): People's Plan Campaign (PPC) 2025-26** "Sabki Yojana, Sabka Vikas" + **SabhaSaar** AI tool recording Gram Sabha in 13 languages — technology meets grassroots democracy
- **SVAMITVA Scheme:** 2.75+ crore property cards via drone surveys in 3.28 lakh villages — land rights digitization empowering rural communities
- **National Panchayati Raj Day 2026:** Theme "Sashakt Panchayat, Sarvangeen Vikas" — localizing SDGs through PRIs

Conclusion: Panchayati Raj is not just local governance but a **tool of social change**. It empowers marginalized groups, promotes health, education, and development, safeguards tribal rights through PESA. By decentralizing power, it drives inclusive growth and strengthens grassroots democracy.

TOPIC 7: MEDIA & SOCIAL CHANGE

Paper 2 — Chapter 5.3 | Also relevant to GS1 (Role of Media in Social Change)

What is Media?

Marshall McLuhan

"The medium is the message" — media not only carries information but **shapes how people think and act**, directly influencing social change.

Types of Media

Type	Examples
Print Media	Newspapers, magazines, pamphlets
Broadcast Media	Radio and television
Digital Media	Internet, social media, online platforms

Positive Impacts of Media — 7 Dimensions

Impact	Example / Case Study
1. Giving voice to people	Media coverage of Dongria Khond tribe's agitation against Vedanta's bauxite mining in Niyamgiri range → Supreme Court order (18 April 2013): mining clearance only if Dongrias agree
2. Awareness about wrongs	Coverage of honour killings, khap panchayats , lynchings → mobilised action against them
3. Uplifting marginal sections	Uplifting Ghasi (SC community of Odisha) by preventing social discrimination; Exposing FRA 2006 loopholes (rejection of appeals at patwari level); #MeToo , #BlackLivesMatter
4. Revival of dying languages	Asur Community using mobile radio to spread Asur language — listed in UNESCO Interactive Atlas of World's Languages in Danger (only 7,000-8,000 speakers). Led by Sushma Asur
5. Women empowerment	Subhash — study "Impact of Mass Media on Women: A Sociological Study of Gulbarga District" — mass media enabled women's empowerment, improved learning, advocated gender equality
6. Media and democracy	Ensures informed choices by citizens; "checking function" ensuring elected representatives uphold their oath
7. Media and social justice	Educating, raising awareness, questioning caste discrimination

Negative Impacts of Media — 7 Concerns

Negative Impact	Details / Example
1. Dangers to Socialization	Fixed to TV screens; reduced time with family/children; developing generation gap
2. Fake news	Creating tensions between communities; WhatsApp lynchings
3. Yellow Journalism / Sensationalism	Former CJI N. V. Ramana : media is running " kangaroo courts " — ill-informed, biased, agenda-driven debates affecting justice delivery
4. Distortion of elections	Paid news distorting free and fair elections
5. Impact on diet and body image	Mass media shapes ideal body images → impact on mental health; promotes junk food consumption
6. Media and criminal justice	Law enforcement under pressure to selectively reveal investigation details or mischaracterize incidents. Bhima Koregaon (2018) : Motivated arrests of popular dissenters critical of Government
7. Trial by media	Disha (Priyanka Reddy) murder case, 2019 : Media organized rallies demanding "encounter" justice → all four accused killed in alleged police encounter on 6 December 2019

Case Study: Dongria Khond / Niyamgiri (2013)

- Dongria Khond tribe opposed Vedanta's bauxite mining in their sacred Niyamgiri hills (Odisha)
- **Media coverage** of their agitation brought national/international attention
- **SC order (18 April 2013)**: Mining clearance ONLY if Dongria Khonds agree through Gram Sabha
- 12 Gram Sabhas unanimously rejected mining
- **Significance**: First time tribal consent (FPIC) upheld over corporate interests through media-enabled public pressure

Case Study: Asur Community & Language Revival

- Asur = Austroasiatic-speaking tribe of Jharkhand (iron smelters)
- Only **7,000-8,000 speakers** left — listed in UNESCO Atlas of Endangered Languages
- **Sushma Asur** led initiative using **mobile radio** to broadcast in Asur language
- Songs, stories, cultural knowledge transmitted through digital media
- **Significance**: Shows how new media technology can reverse language death — community-driven preservation

Case Study: Disha / Priyanka Reddy Case (2019)

- Veterinarian gangraped and murdered in Hyderabad (Nov 2019)
- Media organized rallies, demanded "encounter" justice rather than trial
- All 4 accused killed in alleged police encounter on **6 December 2019**
- **Significance:** Classic example of "trial by media" undermining rule of law; media shaped public opinion to sanction extra-judicial killing



Anthropological Significance & Contemporary Relevance

- **Media anthropology:** A growing subfield studying how media **constructs reality** — what gets covered, what's invisible, whose voice is amplified
- **Digital ethnography:** Anthropologists now study online communities, memes, social media movements as cultural phenomena — new fieldwork sites
- **Subaltern voice:** Media empowers communities traditionally studied BY anthropologists to **represent themselves** — shifts power dynamics (Asur mobile radio = self-representation)
- **Sanskritization via media:** TV serials (Ramayana, Mahabharata), online poojas, WhatsApp religious forwards = **media as new agent of Sanskritization** (connects to Topic 1)
- **Minority representation:** Media either **stereotypes** minorities (Muslims as terrorists, tribals as primitive) or **empowers** them (Dongria Khond coverage) — dual role
- **Language preservation:** Community radio, podcasts in tribal languages, YouTube channels = technology-enabled ethnolinguistic survival (connects to Topic 4 - Linguistic Minorities)
- **Ethical dimension:** Anthropological principle of "do no harm" applies to media too — sensational coverage of tribal ceremonies can lead to cultural commodification and loss of sacred meaning

Conclusion: Media is both a **mirror and a motor of social change**. It informs, empowers, and challenges social hierarchies, while also shaping new values and practices. Despite risks like fake news, its role in democracy, social justice, and cultural transformation makes it a **central driver of change** in contemporary society.

CURRENT HOOKS — Recent Developments (2025-26)

Use these in Mains answers for freshness and contemporary relevance

Panchayati Raj — PPC 2025-26

People's Plan Campaign (PPC) 2025-26 "Sabki Yojana, Sabka Vikas" — focuses on tribal empowerment via **Adi Karmayogi Abhiyaan**. Enhances transparency, accountability, inclusive rural development. 2,54,604 Gram Panchayats (96.36%) uploaded their GPDPs on eGramSwaraj.

Digital Governance — SabhaSaar AI Tool

SabhaSaar = AI-powered tool that digitally records Gram Sabha proceedings in **13 languages**. Improves documentation, accountability, and citizen participation. Represents convergence of modernization + Panchayati Raj + media.

Land Rights — SVAMITVA Scheme

2.75+ crore property cards generated through drone surveys in **3.28 lakh villages**. Digitizes rural land ownership — empowers communities with legal documentation. Reduces land disputes.

National Panchayati Raj Day 2026

Theme: "**Sashakt Panchayat, Sarvangeen Vikas**" (Empowered Panchayats, Holistic Development). Focus on localising **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)** and strengthening digital governance through e-Gram Swaraj. Vision: "Viksit Bharat" by 2047.

Minority Status — SC Ruling (2024-25)

Supreme Court ruled minority status is "**state-dependent**" — states can grant minority status to any community including Hindus. Validates anthropological view that identity is **contextual, not absolute**. Union Govt told SC that Ranganath Mishra Commission report was "flawed" and rejected (Dec 2023).

Re-Sanskritization Trend (Contemporary)

Growing inclination towards **ancient Indian philosophy, yoga, naturopathy, rural lifestyles, traditional dressing** = contemporary forms of re-sanskritization. International Yoga Day, Ayush Ministry push, PM's emphasis on Indian knowledge systems — all signal cultural assertion against perceived over-Westernization.



QUICK REVISION CHEAT SHEET

Last-minute scan before the exam — all 7 topics in one spread

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Examples	Key Case Studies
Sanskritization	Cultural emulation → cultural erosion; symbolic not structural; dowry replaces bride price; dominant caste models (Brahmin/Kshatriya/Vaishya); paradox (claim high + retain backward); new agents (media, online poojas); tribe → caste through Sanskritization	Srinivas (1952, coined), Harold Gould (repressed hostility), Milton Singer (political participation), Yogendra Singh (varna), William Rowe (less functional)	Rajwars/Koyeris/Dusadh (Bihar); Gonds, Meena (Rajasthan); Tirupati online booking; Breast tax abolition	Nangeli (Travancore breast tax protest)
Re/De-sanskritization	Resanskritization = return after moving away; Desanskritization = abandon Sanskrit + revive indigenous; both challenge linear view of social change	Basavanna (12th C Lingayat founder)	Arya Samaj later generations; Adi Dharma (Bengal Dalits); Sarna code demand	Lingayats (Karnataka); Ramnamis (Chhattisgarh); Sarna Revivalism (Jharkhand)
Westernization	150+ yrs British rule; value-loaded; accelerates & weakens Sanskritization; 3 global views (conflict/optimistic/critical); 5 limitations (Eurocentric, static West); gave India nationalism + democracy	Srinivas (coined), Huntington (clash), Mahubani (Asian rise), Edward Said (Orientalism), John McLane (nationalism), B.R. Nanda (Nehru), Harold Gould (distinction)	Raja Ram Mohan Roy; Nehru "last Englishman"; Swadeshi movement; higher castes using Western education as distinction	—
Modernization	Rational attitude; progress; less value-loaded than W; 3 roots (Neolithic/Industrial/Protestant Ethic); empathy-mobility-participation (Lerner); Indian model = democracy+secularism+social justice; not uniform; alternative modernities exist	Eisenstadt (historical process), Yogendra Singh (rational attitude), S.C. Dube (1974/1988 — own model), Daniel Lerner (3 features), Max Weber (1904 Protestant Ethic), Dabholkar (anti-superstition)	Green Revolution (Mexico/Philippines); Ambedkar's rise; Saudi Vision 2030; NCRB 74 witchcraft deaths; Digital India/UPI	—
Religious Minorities	6 notified groups (Jains added 2014); Art 29/30/350A/350B; 7 problems (identity/security/equity/communal/representation/politicization/fear); Sachar (2.5% bureaucracy); Ranganath Mishra (10%+5% reservation, delink SC); "Minorities" only 4 places in Constitution	Lord Acton (freedom test), Sachar Committee (data), Ranganath Mishra Commission (recommendations)	Muzaffarnagar 2013; Godhra 2002; CAA 2019; Shaheen Bagh; UNDP MPI 2018	Karnataka Hijab (2022) — HC upheld ban; Malala & HRW criticized
Linguistic Minorities	State-level determination (not national); spoken language sufficient, no script needed; 6 problems (funds/diversity/grievance/discrimination/erosion/economic); Art 350-A/B; 7th Amendment 1956	XAXA Committee (PVTG education), DAV College case (1971 — spoken language), TA Pai Foundation (state context)	Tribal language shift to English; endangered languages (UNESCO Atlas)	—
Growth of Anthropology	4 phases: Formative (documentation, 1774-1919) → Constructive (institutions, 1920-49) → Analytical (theory, 1950-90) → Evaluative (applied, 1990+); Asiatic Society 1774; AnSI 1945; Man in India 1921; village monographs 1950s-60s	Sir William Jones (1774), H.H. Risley (Census), S.C. Roy (Man in India/Munda 1912), Verrier Elwin (Baiga/isolationist), B.S. Guha (AnSI), L.P. Vidyarthi (sacred/NMS complex)	Tribes & Castes of Bengal; Munda & Their Country; The Baiga; 25th ISC 1938; People of India Project (K.S. Singh)	—
Panchayati Raj	3-tier (Gram/Samiti/Zilla); direct democracy; 50% women reservation (Bihar first); "Sarpanch pati" problem; PESA for tribal self-governance; Gram Sabha = inclusive; decentralized planning; social change tool	Anderson & Parker (social change def), Surinder Jodhka (values/institutions), PM Modi (Sarpanch pati)	Bihar 50% women; PPC 2025-26; SabhaSaar AI (13 languages); SVAMITVA drones	Bhim tehsil (alcohol ban, 2015); Latak (bamboo bridge, Assam); Digampur (WB)

				— GPVY prize winner)
Media & Social Change	"Medium is the message" (McLuhan); 7 positives (voice, awareness, uplift, language, women, democracy, justice); 7 negatives (socialization, fake news, kangaroo courts, elections, body image, criminal justice, trial by media); mirror + motor of change	Marshall McLuhan (medium=message), CJI N.V. Ramana (kangaroo courts), Subhash (Gulbarga women study), Sushma Asur (language revival)	#MeToo; #BLM; Asur mobile radio; Ghasi community (Odisha); paid news; WhatsApp lynchings	Dongria Khond/Niyamgiri (SC 2013); Disha case (2019 encounter); Bhima Koregaon (2018 arrests)



Master Mnemonic for All 7 Topics = "SWM — MA — PM"

Sanskritization → **W**esternization → **M**odernization = Processes of Change

Minorities (Religious + Linguistic) = Subjects of Change

Anthropology Growth = Study of Change

Panchayati Raj + **M**edia = Agents of Change

Remember: "SWiM-MA-PM" (swim in the PM session!)

Critical Inter-linkages for Mains Answers:

- Sanskritization ↔ Westernization = accelerate & weaken each other (always mention both in social change questions)
- Media = NEW agent of Sanskritization (online poojas, TV festivals) AND of modernization (Digital India)
- PRI + Media = drivers of social change for minorities & tribals (PESA + media empowerment)
- PESA connects PRI with tribal rights; Dongria Khond case connects media with tribal rights
- Growth of Anthropology Phase 3 scholars (Srinivas, Vidyarthi) studied all these processes
- Minorities face challenges from BOTH Sanskritization (homogenization) AND incomplete modernization (economic marginalization)
- Desanskritization (Sarna) + PESA + media = triple empowerment tool for tribal identity assertion